

A Simulated Collapse:
Norme's Solitary Confinement Live Stream

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On October 15th, 2024, YouTuber Norme launched a non-stop live stream of himself titled, *1 Month in Solitary Confinement, No Light*  *LIVE 24/7* . He started the stream off loudly proclaiming, “Chat, this is a science experiment to see what will happen if I spend 30 days in solitary confinement, in complete darkness,” and that he and his viewers will “hopefully find out together if I go crazy or not.”¹ Viewers of this stream could witness Norme’s “science experiment” through continuous footage shot from an infrared camera, which was supposedly projecting a single red light into Norme’s otherwise dark room.² This red light, along with an audio output that generates mechanical speech from the stream’s chat, became Norme’s primary means of engagement with his audience. He could see the light by which he was made visible to the stream, and he could hear the responses of chat to his performance. Other than that, Norme was supposedly left alone in the dark, performing a “scientific” test focused on the result of what this kind of social isolation might do to his interior psychology.

Beyond the text-to-speech chat feature, this live stream also incorporated a few options for audience engagement in the form of donations; at first, there were only three: 5 USD to make him do a handstand, 20 USD to make him put on a straight-jacket for one hour, and 50 USD to make him tape his mouth shut for one hour.³ These options were presented to his audience in the top left corner of the screen; above them was a clock keeping track of the elapsed time of the stream, and below, a screen scrolling through the most recent messages sent to the stream through its live chat feature (see Fig. 1). But despite the obvious ability for audience engagement and interference within the stream, the stream’s seemingly objective camera allowed it to take on

¹ Norme, "1 Month in Solitary Confinement, No Light  *LIVE 24/7* .https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aBB2A8pR8FQ.

² Norme, "1 Month in Solitary Confinement, No Light  *LIVE 24/7* .

³ Ibid.

the appearance of a raw historical document: a documentation of Norme's "real" mental collapse that the individual audience member could seemingly witness first-hand.



Fig. 1: Norme at the start of the live stream.⁴

The camera, with its non-stop coverage and ability to see through the darkness of Norme's current condition, feels like the closest thing to a reliable depiction of this event. While Norme is constantly aware of it, and chat's presence, the camera itself feels like nothing but a quiet mediation that affords the audience the ability to witness Norme suffer without any consequences. Norme doesn't speak *to the camera*, Norme speaks to chat *through the camera*, as though it isn't there. But this blind trust in the subtle mediation at the heart of the live stream is in fact the heart of its trick. This faith allows it to turn the reality of what occurs in front of the camera into a predetermined outcome: where Norme loses his mind over the course of this over 700-hour "experiment."

⁴ Norme, "1 Month in Solitary Confinement, No Light ●LIVE 24/7●."

Jean Baudrillard, a postmodern philosopher and sociologist, writes about a similar sort of non-stop, reality television production that captures the psychological destruction of its chosen subject, the Loud family. In reference to this uninterrupted depiction of the Loud family's collapse in 1971, Baudrillard states the television show produced the "illusion of filming the Louds *as if TV weren't there*," which allowed for this paradoxical camera, which seemingly had no place in the represented reality of the Louds, to afford the audience a virtually objective viewing experience, "as if *you* were there."⁵ In the case of Norme's live stream, a very similar effect occurs. The viewer must acknowledge the presence of the camera; after all, it's the only means by which Norme is made visible to them. However, this camera seemingly falls away as though *you*, the audience, are there, truly witnessing and talking with Norme in its place. This effect relies on a concept Baudrillard details earlier in his writings on simulation: the ability for representations to dissimulate the fact that they're representations at all, a necessary step for a simulation of reality to make claims to truth.⁶

According to Baudrillard, to dissimulate is to "pretend not to have what one has," while to simulate is to "feign to have what one doesn't have."⁷ Effectively, both of these instances of non-stop film are dissimulating the camera's presence and simulating a reality where the viewer can take the camera's place, allowing its sight and presence to feel like their own. Norme's camera is physically there, without narratively being there; it becomes a supposedly neutral avenue by which the audience is shown "objective footage" of Norme's behavior. The neutral camera enables them to witness and interact with this "reality," without revealing the truth of its mediation. This simultaneous dissimulation of the camera and simulation of an occupiable reality is made possible by the exactitude of the camera's vision. Its seemingly objective visual

⁵ Jean Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation* (Ann Arbor, Mich: University of Michigan Press, 2021), 28.

⁶ Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation*, 6.

⁷ Ibid., 3.

representation of the material world performs what Baudrillard describes as “the substitution of the signs of the real for the real,” where a representation dissimulates its inequivalence with reality, allowing it to then simulate its own reality.⁸ The camera’s visual exactitude and the accompanying signs of the real are what simulate an occupiable reality in the space of the now dissimulated camera.

Signs of the real, such as the exactitude of Norme’s camera, are by necessity not the real itself, given the fact that they remain detached from reality within a system of representation. However, according to Baudrillard, signs of the real are believed to be capable of equivalently exchanging themselves for reality.⁹ And for signs to exchange themselves for what they represent, they rely on the “wager on representation,” this wager being: “that a sign could refer to the depth of meaning, that a sign could be exchanged for meaning and that something could guarantee this exchange – God of course.”¹⁰ In the secular age, without a God to guarantee this exchange, systems of signs are supposedly left separate from the real; they intend to impart a real meaning, however, they only reflect reality as an opposing image of it.

But Baudrillard asks, “What if God himself can be simulated, that is, to be reduced to the signs that constitute faith?”¹¹ In this case, “the whole system becomes weightless,” and no longer needs a reality to exchange itself for, as the signs themselves, through their simulation of a guarantor have made their claim to reality: “it is no longer itself anything but a gigantic simulacrum,” no longer unreal, but “exchanged for itself,” to establish its own truth.¹² These systems of representation that simulate their own guarantor no longer need anything to facilitate

⁸ Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation*, 2.

⁹ Ibid., 5.

¹⁰ Ibid.

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Ibid., 5-6.

this exchange: these simulacrum simply become real through the dissimulation of their subjective origin.

To establish a simulacrum by equivalently exchanging signs of the real for the faith in their reflected reality is akin to semiologist and literary theorist Roland Barthes' concept of the referential illusion, where "the concrete detail" of a fictive reality "is constituted by the direct collusion of a referent and a signifier."¹³ The referent in this case refers to the reflected reality, and the signifier refers to that which depicts it. This direct collusion relies on the idea that the signified, the counterpart of the signifier that typically holds its meaning, "is expelled from the sign," or in other words, is dissimulated as a part of the sign.¹⁴ The referential illusion that occurs due to this dissimulation of subjective meaning, in a way, simulates the signs that constitute faith in the real; by producing a representation of reality that feels as though it can be embodied, the signifier/referent guarantees itself and establishes a self-sufficient simulacrum. Barthes also notes that this meaningless signifier/referent, a purely denotative and simulative representation of "concrete" reality, is of "essential reference in historical narrative, which is supposed to report 'what really happened.'"¹⁵ These signs that dissimulate their own signified meaning and simulate this referential illusion become the backbone of historical discourse. For Norme's stream then, the visually "concrete detail" of the camera becomes this sort of pure reference, or simulacrum, that virtually grounds the historical documentation of his isolation in solitary confinement in reality.

In another of Barthes' writings, *The Discourse of History*, he notes that historical documentation and writing "very rarely includes signs of the reader," and that in fact, historical

¹³ Roland Barthes, *The Rustle of Language*. Translated by Richard Howard. (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2010), 147.

¹⁴ Barthes, *The Rustle of Language*, 147

¹⁵ Ibid., 146.

discourse is often “a discourse without a you.”¹⁶ At first, this feels as though it may contradict the structure of Norme’s stream, being one that is at all times glaringly aware of the audience. However, this absence of the reader is an effect that occurs only after the capture of the historical event, as Norme’s livestream only directly addresses the “you” present in the moment of the discourse itself. After the fact, the stream feels as though it rejects the presence of the audience, while still allowing them to virtually witness the occurrence. If one views the stream in retrospect the “you” of chat seems to look like nothing but a separate “you” from oneself; the audience becomes a character in the historical drama separate from the person witnessing it in post.

Similarly, after the live stream has taken place, the presence of Norme as an author feels less palpable. The camera, by having dissimulated its presence through acting as a hyperreal medium for engagement between Norme and chat, dissimulates the presence of a historical author in post. This could be akin to what Barthes calls the “empty subject of the speech-act” which takes shape according to the way history is arranged in narrative form.¹⁷ But again, the hyperreality of the camera keeps this empty subject empty by simulating an intense referential illusion; the history of Norme’s stream is seemingly untouched and purely referential. Barthes describes this as when “the historian intends to ‘absent himself’ from his discourse,” and in turn allows for the totalizing narrative illusion in which “history seems to *tell itself*.”¹⁸ In just the same way that signs of the real dissimulate their origin and meaning as signs to create the referential illusion, historical discourse, as a complex sign in its own right, can cast its whole narrative in a referential illusion by dissimulating its subjective origin. After the live stream has

¹⁶ Barthes, *The Rustle of Language*, 131.

¹⁷ Ibid.

¹⁸ Ibid.

ended, Norme isn't held liable as the historian; the camera simply witnessed the events and had nothing to do with his seemingly real mental collapse.

This "so-called objective historical discourse," is created only by the substitution of the historian's "emotive person" for "the 'objective' person;" through the dissimulation of a historically unreliable viewpoint, history simulates in its stead an "objective subject," a paradoxical narrator that can view all of reality, including itself, in a purely referential state.¹⁹ This referential and objective illusion is further supported in Norme's stream by what Barthes notes to be the "supreme sign of objectivity," when the "speaker (or writer) of the discourse is at the same time a participant in the process spoken."²⁰ This distancing seemingly produces a kind of historical alibi that affords the historian the role of the "objective subject" given the discourse "objectively" depicts the historian as a part of the text in a referential third-person. Barthes further details that the "most illustrious example of this conjunction between the spoken I," the narrator as participant, "and the speaking I," the narrator as writer, "is doubtless the *he* of Julius Caesar. This famous *he* belongs to the statement; when Caesar becomes explicitly the "writer," *he* shifts to *we*."²¹ In the case of Norme's live stream, his position as the author of the text dissimulates itself through the referential illusion of a third-person camera as narrator. The camera seemingly exists independent of Norme's whims, signifying an ability to objectively perceive his incredibly subjective position. And when Norme refers to himself as the creator of the stream at the start of it, he considers it a joint venture between him and chat: an "I" and "you" that turns into a Caesarian "we."

By using the camera to distance himself as an author during the stream, Norme takes on, through the camera, the role of this supreme "objective subject" in much the same way as

¹⁹ Barthes, *The Rustle of Language*, 132.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Ibid.

Caesar's narration. This dissimulated "I" and simulated "Caesarian *he* supports only certain syntagms which we might call *syntagms of the leader*," which notably affords the historian the ability to "give orders."²² The camera then, as an objective subject, is capable of writing the very structure that defines and orders history. This can be directly seen through the rules put in place for Norme's behavior and for his audience's engagement; the donation features create rules that lay seemingly above Norme's own autonomy, and become the only means by which interaction with Norme is permitted. As a dissimulated historian and leader, Norme sublimates himself underneath his previously established rules, forcing both him and chat to seemingly occupy a similar space of power over the autonomy of history.

These rules then begin to signify a specific kind of history: one with a set list of "existents" and "occurents," which according to Barthes, generate a sort of historical "lexicon" or "collection" that structures the historical discourse.²³ Existents and occurents are effectively defined as "beings, entities, and their predicates," which can be fairly quickly summarized as objects of historical discourse and the events during which they take place.²⁴ Barthes notes as an example of a historical collection or lexicon, one "of warfare," however there are certainly "more complex associations of different lexicons."²⁵ The rules of Norme's stream could certainly be considered a kind of imperative collection of occurrences, of what's allowed to occur within this filmed history. These structurations can also be imbued with an "author's personal thematics," which create stronger, more substantive forms of historical discourse.²⁶ In the case of Norme's stream, the rules that generate a collection of occurrences, such as him putting on mouth tape or a straight-jacket, color the discourse in a kind of thematics, or lexicon of the insane. His history

²² Barthes, *The Rustle of Language*, 132.

²³ Ibid., 133.

²⁴ Ibid.

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ Ibid., 134.

is organized thematically according to the core question of the stream: whether or not he “goes crazy” over the course of this one-month-long challenge. Thus, the seemingly objective discourse of history simulated by Norme’s objective camera is actually simulating a specific kind of history, one in which he’s constantly re-thematizing his actions as already insane.

To return to Baudrillard’s treatment of the Louds, he states that “in fact, it is TV that is the truth of the Louds, it is TV that is true, it is TV that renders true.”²⁷ The form of television itself, rather than merely surveilling and depicting the response of the Loud family to their constant surveillance, generates the ‘real’ events through the entanglement of mediation with reality: “There is no longer a medium in the literal sense: it is now intangible, diffused, and diffracted in the real.”²⁸ Norme’s interactive live stream never simply depicted the real; rather, through the feedback and options provided by the dissimulated camera, it simulated and generated a reality that rendered its own form of history true. The medium by which the audience engaged with Norme *became* the historical reality of the stream instead of merely *denoting* it, given it was the only afforded means for the occurrences of audience engagement. But this seemingly objective force of the camera, which dominates the audience as well as Norme, while simulating reality, was taken for granted. It became an embodied thematic reality, without question of how or why; the audience was simply ordered to enact the history Norme had predetermined via his established occurrences.

But despite the apparent connotative significance of this “lexicon of the insane,” the real, denotative state of Norme’s interior psychology is constantly outside the bounds of the third-person, objective camera’s discourse. As a part of this historical trick, Norme is estranged from the point-of-view of the historical camera and reduced to the Caesarian “he,” separate from

²⁷ Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation*, 28-29.

²⁸ *Ibid.*, 30.

his actual narration; his “true” first-person experience is incapable of being witnessed by the audience since he’s necessarily separate from their embodied and objective point-of-view. This creates something akin to what critic of the Nouveau Romancier, Bruce Morrisette, would consider a narrative hole: “a large blank in the printed text,” such as the “implied psychology of the protagonist,” which structures itself around the “elements that have been suppressed within the hole or that are used to fill it with true or false ‘content.’”²⁹ Norme’s psychology becomes a kind of narrative blank of suppressed information, an interior vanishing point beyond what the exterior behaviorist account of the camera permits us to see.

The third-person, exterior, and objective account of his psychology at first seems unlikely to permit us a view into this hole, the supposedly collapsing mind of Norme. In fact, Morrisette initially claims that the “first-person narration” which “dissimulates the origin of the narrative text, creates an illusion of reality,” affords the reader the ability “to project himself to the utmost into the situation of the narrator.”³⁰ If Norme was to audibly recount to the audience his interior psychology during the stream, this wouldn’t be dissimilar from how first-person narration often supplements the inability to access such interiors in third-person narrative: “Nearly all third-person novels teem with “bridging” techniques used to shift the view-point to the first-person: self-quotations to represent thoughts.”³¹ However, Morrisette later reveals that the first-person narrator actually proves to problematize “real” projection more than the third since the truth of interiority is easily dissimulated through “suppression of information by a first-person narrator.”³² If Norme were to simply say he’s “gone crazy,” we lack the ability as an

²⁹ Morrisette, *Novel and Film : Essays in Two Genres*, (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1985), 74-75.

³⁰ Morrisette, *Novel and Film : Essays in Two Genres*, 95.

³¹ Ibid., 98.

³² Ibid.

audience to discern what he's simulating or dissimulating about his current condition; his reliability as a first-person narrator is inherently faulty.

So this third-person camera that is set up "between himself and the reader" acts as "an opaque screen that prevents the latter from seeing into the mind of the narrator," which actually "serves to emphasize the [narrator's] alienation from the norm."³³ By using the camera as a dissimulated narrator, in the form of Caesar's "we," Norme's psychology is made to seem even more alienated from the embodied space of the viewer. Because viewers cannot see into his mind directly, his collapsing psychology remains unknowable to the camera, and therefore a more objective representation of an unstable interiority. This is further supported by the lexicon of the insane which grounds the stream through signs of the real and its objective occurrences which continuously depict Norme as having already lost his mind.

However, the camera's depiction of his behavior, which is still an aspect of Norme as narrator and objective historian, resembles Morrissette's notion of the narrative perspective, "je-néant," which "may be defined as a technique of the suppressed first person in which all pronouns or forms associated with it...are eliminated."³⁴ This "je-néant" bears a striking similarity to the form of the absent narrator of "objective" historical documentation, where its presence as a single, subjective author is dissimulated. The position of the writer and camera then becomes this kind of hidden first-person, this je-néant: a missing viewpoint, where "the reader installs himself and seeing, hearing, witnessing what the [narrator] perceives, [and] is obliged to assume the narrator's vision of things and to create without verbal clues or instructions his own interpretation of scenes and events."³⁵ But in the case of both Caesar and Norme, this dissimulation of the "I" is made possible by simulating an alienated and inaccessible

³³ Morrissette, *Novel and Film : Essays in Two Genres*, 105.

³⁴ Ibid.

³⁵ Ibid., 106.

interior psychology of the narrator in the text. The camera, or Caesarian “we” then becomes something like an anterior perspective, one in which the narrating “je-néant” simultaneously simulates the interior aspects of the protagonist’s psychology through its virtual descriptions of embodied space, whilst dissimulating the “objective” psychology of their alienated counterpart within the text. Through the stream’s form, the je-néant camera bridges Norme’s interior psychology, seemingly invisible to us, and the exterior signs of the insanity displayed inside the room that first-person Norme is actually blind to.

The room in a sense, then, becomes a constant sign of his alienated interiority; locked away and separate from the rest of the world, except for through the simulating camera of his own design. As the stream progresses, the psychological space simulated by the camera only continues to unravel: around 491 hours into the stream, Norme is egged on by chat to break a hole in the door, which encloses him inside of this room.³⁶ He complies and begins to toss himself over and over, headfirst at the door, using his body like a battering ram. The door eventually gives, and his head slides through to the other side. Over the course of the rest of the live stream, the door continues to fall apart, and becomes a sort of signifier for his mental conditioning worsening over time: a sort of connoted mental rot (see Fig. 2). The interior psychology that was simulated by the conditions of the room itself opens up through a hole to the outside. Norme no longer has an interior psychology; his depicted and simulated mental state prolapses through the representation of a hole. Like Morrisette’s notion of the narrative topology of the hole, this real hole begins to simulate for the viewer Norme’s own lack of self-awareness and internal regulation, originally thought to exist separately from the external simulation of the stream. The simulated exterior has become the real interior; as the hole

³⁶ Norme, "1 Month in Solitary Confinement with No Light WORLD RECORD," Video, 2:30:41. YouTube. November 5, 2024. Accessed April 30, 2025. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XR3X_xPEogo.

continues to widen, destroying the notions of inside and outside, Norme becomes nothing but a character in his own simulated history.



Fig. 2: The hole and door at the end of the stream.³⁷

But as the distinctions between the psychology simulated through the referential illusion of the environment and the interior hole of Norme's real psychology blur, where do the viewers active during the stream find themselves? Morrissette notes that the "voice that says vous," or "you," could be considered "less that of a character than of the author or, better still, that of a persona invisible, but powerfully present, who serves as the center of consciousness in the novel."³⁸ The voice that implicates the reader in this instance bears a striking resemblance to the similarly invisible yet present "je-néant," the camera, or the Caesarean narrator that writes "we," that's both inside and out of the text at the same time. The camera's donation options and chat, which call out towards "you," the active viewer, then blur the lines that differentiate Norme

³⁷ Norme, "1 Month in Solitary Confinement with No Light WORLD RECORD." Video, 5:23:55. YouTube, November 14, 2024. Accessed April 30, 2025. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4pmXtcE45bo>.

³⁸ Morrissette, *Novel and Film : Essays in Two Genres*, 131.

alienated in the first person, as well as the viewer; the voice that says “you” can simultaneously refer to the both of these subjects, given their joint sublimation under the narration and dictating force of the camera’s lexicon.

This makes sense, given the ability of the voice that says “we,” which holds the syntagm of the leader, to give orders to others; Morrisette points out that the second-person holds “a certain implication of the imperative: that is, “you” are instructed, if not ordered,” to act a certain way by the narration.³⁹ Both the viewers and Norme, once sublimated by this leading “je-néant” occupy the same kind of position. “You” becomes a simultaneous external and self-reference as it refers to the actions the external viewer can take, as well as how the internal, alienated narrator of Norme must act. The camera’s options metaphorically yell out to the viewer, “you can donate to make Norme wear a straight-jacket,” while simultaneously dictating to Norme, “you must wear a straight-jacket if a viewer donates.” Their agency is blurred, and Norme becomes an alienated vessel for the audience, dedicated by the camera. The referential illusion of the stream simulates Norme’s interior psychology, while the use of “you” allows the viewer to simulate taking control of his body. The products of this simulation, these rules for interaction on the stream and Norme’s behaviors that are generated by them, are then all made real by the viewer’s experience of and engagement with it. Through the objectified viewpoint of the imperative camera, the simulating je-néant, Norme’s simulated psychology becomes their own.

The scene in which Norme breaks down the door with his head is emblematic of this fact. The chat’s ability to control Norme’s body and simulate action through him broke out of the limited constraints of donation options; instead, chat simply egged Norme on. Before he mobilized himself as a battering ram, chat spoke out to him saying, “norme get angry dont let that stupid door win,” or, “the door beat norme,” which Norme repeated back to the camera,

³⁹ Morrisette, *Novel and Film : Essays in Two Genres*, 110.

twice over, like a parrot.⁴⁰ He walked back and forth, hitting his body against the door, listening to chat spam over his apparent loss, before finally hearing, “norme lost against the door before mister beast,” which seemingly set him off.⁴¹ He placed his hands against the door and began to launch himself into it, to break a hole in the door, which was originally chat’s idea.⁴² The camera’s chat becomes a space that simulates his self-destruction beyond what the established lexicon of insanity Norme had originally designed. If the request falls within the thematic resemblance of his simulation of mental collapse, such as breaking a hole open in his door with his head, Norme acts, and chat embodies Norme as a kind of historical puppet of his own design.

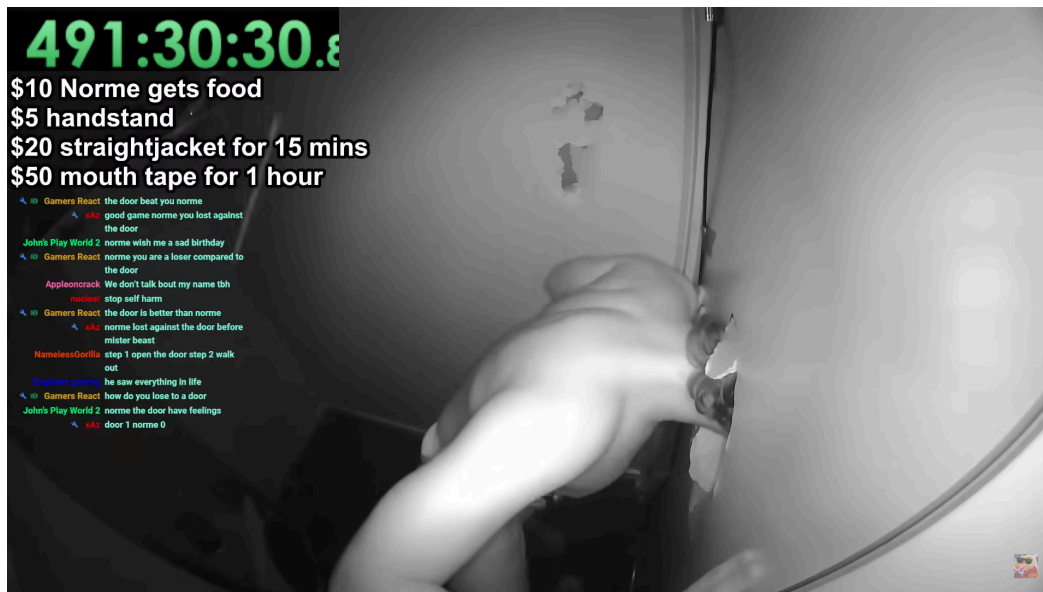


Fig. 3: Norme beats the door at the request of chat.⁴³

Norme’s live stream is one of pure submission, wherein the camera, calling out to the stream-viewer, commands them to experience the stream according to Norme’s pre-determined, self-sufficient, and seemingly “real” mode of viewing his loss of sanity. Requests and pleas to

⁴⁰ Norme, "1 Month in Solitary Confinement with No Light WORLD RECORD," November 5, 2024.

⁴¹ Ibid.

⁴² Ibid.

⁴³ Ibid.

stop the stream for his mental and physical well-being are ignored; they have no place in his simulation. As he continues to harm himself on camera, according to the rules and lexicon established by the camera, chat can contribute to this narration, as commanded of them by the rules of the stream itself, and Norme complies willingly. The damage done to his psyche takes shape in the historical documentation of the room's collapse. The dissimulated *je-néant* camera guarantees proof of Norme's real psychology by capturing these signs of simulated reality. And through the audience's embodiment in that simulation, they seemingly witness the material "reality" of his fracturing psyche.

This approach to a psychological "experiment" was not only pre-destined to result in his simulated mental collapse because of the guiding camera, loaded with the lexicon of the insane but also because Norme himself was less aware of his own visible physical reality than those observing the simulation of it. He was left blind in the dark, where his only gauge of his disposition became chat itself. The real in this case, if the real was the hole in which Norme's interior psychology was dissimulated, was purely overwritten by what chat told him. Chat became Norme's only mirror, a sort of feedback loop that consistently guaranteed him that each and every action of performative insanity was real. Through its simulacral depiction of history guaranteed by the referential illusion of the camera, Norme's chat was assured and faithful that he was going insane, which consistently made Norme trust all the more that the supposedly objective view which he alienated himself from was the truth itself. The result of this was nothing short of a simulated tragedy, wherein Norme's joke and performance seemingly overwrote his sense of self.

Nearing the end of Baudrillard's discussion of the Loud family's collapse at the hand of reality television, he states that in the hyperreal state of society, "it becomes impossible to locate

one instance of the model, of power, of the gaze, of the medium itself because *you* are always already on the other side.”⁴⁴ In this era of hyperreal social interaction, wherein the medium of social media is already diffused and diffracted within our individual perceptions of reality, it becomes difficult to distinguish oneself from the perception of the model they project online. The feedback provided by the “chat” of the internet, as well as how this feedback constitutes and permeates the ability to form self-recognition reveals that the self is potentially, already only that which constitutes its virtual model. Viewers of online personas become engineered witnesses, and guarantors to a history built on individual referential illusions. The signs that determine their engagement are pre-arranged by their medium, just as Norme’s psyche was fated to domination by the gaze of his imperative camera. And as Norme stared through the red light of the I.R. camera, towards a chat that could see him better than himself, it becomes apparent that “it is the camera lens that, like a laser, comes to pierce lived reality in order to put it to death,” giving rise to nothing but the simulacrum of a real self.⁴⁵

⁴⁴ Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation*, 29.

⁴⁵ Ibid., 28.

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